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DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

Dubai Airports is set to award a further Dh55 billion worth of construction contracts before the end of the year, as work on Al Maktoum International Airport (DWC) continues at full pace, its chief executive has revealed.

Paul Griffiths told reporters at a media roundtable yesterday that Dh13 billion of contracts are already under construction, with the additional Dh55 billion to be awarded in various packages over the coming months.

"We've already in the last 15 months committed 10 million work hours of activity to the new project," Griffiths said.

"17,000 piles are already in the ground, and 45 million cubic metres of earth has been moved at DWC. What other proof do you need that our confidence in the future is completely unfazed given the development of the new airport?"

Asked whether construction had slowed given the wider regional situation, Griffiths was blunt. "I have a one-word answer, and that is no," he said.

Mobilising suppliers

He acknowledged that global supply chains remain under strain, a challenge he said has persisted "really since the end of Covid", but insisted Dubai Airports was working around it. "We're mobilising suppliers from all the way across the world to ensure the project is completed on time," he said.

Griffiths described DWC as far more than a theoretical project. "All the numbers I've quoted at you are actually things that are happening now, and it reinforces our confidence that Al Maktoum International is not some theoretical project; it's actually happening," he said.

The urgency, he explained, comes down to simple maths.

Dh55 billion in new contracts expected by year-end at DWC

DUBAI AIRPORTS CEO REVEALS CONSTRUCTION PACE REMAINS UNAFFECTED



AIRLINES TO SOAR

Passenger numbers are currently running at around 80 per cent of pre-disruption levels, with capacity back to 86 per cent, Griffiths said. By the end of the first half, DXB was served by 56 airlines flying to 236 cities across 100 countries, with new routes added most weeks.

"Every week, that gap between last year and this year gets smaller and smaller," he said. "I'm pretty confident by the end of Q3, we'll have a full schedule. We'll have all the airlines back."

Home carriers Emirates and flydubai have posted particularly strong recovery numbers, with load factors and customer satisfaction scores both climbing. "Emirates and flydubai are in the 90s now compared to last year, so that's extremely good," Griffiths said.

— D. G.

"By the time 2032 comes around, we will be at capacity at DXB, and the last thing the city is going to do is to allow its airport infrastructure to constrain its future growth."

Once operations shift to the new hub, Griffiths said, DXB's future would ultimately be a decision for the government.

"I can't see us operating two major hubs in close proximity for any length of time," he added, describing the eventual switchover as "the world's largest airport transition pro-

gramme by a very significant margin."

Fully automated train system

Passengers moving around the vast new campus will do so via a fully automated train system, with Japan's Mitsubishi Heavy Industries (MHI) selected as contractor. Griffiths confirmed MHI's role, adding that the firm already runs the train linking Terminal 3 and Concourse A at DXB.

"They are the providers of our train that goes between

Terminal Three and Concourse A, and they've been selected to be the contractor for the circulation system around DWC," he said.

The system will connect all of DWC's concourses.

Pressed on the finer details, Griffiths said, "It's difficult to describe because it will be a train that will connect all the different concourses together. If you're really interested in trains, I can talk you into the detail of them," he said, adding with a laugh that he might

"spend my weekends riding on it, just for the fun of it".

DWC is being built to eventually handle 260 million passengers a year, forming the centrepiece of Dubai's long-term aviation strategy. The scale of committed spending — thousands of construction workers on site, tens of billions of dirhams in contracts, and a fully integrated transport system in the works — underlines that the project is moving ahead regardless of short-term regional headwinds.

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Nepal floods leave 95 dead; hundreds missing

105 Indians, 37 NRIs, 12 British citizens and three Americans among missing

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

At least 95 people have been killed and nearly 400 travellers are reported missing after devastating flash floods swept through Nepal's Himalayan border region with Tibet, destroying homes, roads and bridges.

Preliminary Nepal Tourism Board figures list 384 travellers — 291 foreigners and 93 Nepalis — as missing or out of contact. They include 105 Indians, 37 NRIs, 12 British citizens and three Americans. Many Indians were travelling for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra.

77 pilgrims missing

Among the missing Indians are 77 pilgrims from Sadhguru's Isha Foundation, who were at an immigration office while returning from Kailash Mansarovar in Tibet, according to the spiritual leader. Officials cautioned that many could simply



AP

■ A boy looks at the devastation caused by flash flooding along the Trishuli River in Nepal.

be unreachable as roads and communications are severed.

Across the border, Chinese state media said 265 people were missing in Tibet's Gyirong County. Fourteen helicopters have joined rescue operations in Nepal, where at least 28 police personnel are also reported missing. Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to Nepal PM Balendra Shah and offered humanitarian assistance.

Experts believe a rock-ice avalanche may have blocked the Lhunde River and unleashed the flood, while another upstream blockage has raised fears of a second surge.

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